THE BATTLE OF ARTEMISIUM

GRECO-PERSIAN WARS



THE BATTLE OF ARTEMISIUM

Date	August 480 BCE
Location	Off the island of Euboea, western Greece
Result	Inconclusive battle

COMBATANTS

PERSIA	GREEK CITY-STATES

COMMANDERS

Achaemenes	Eurybiades, Themistocles

FORCES

Ships: c.900 triremes	**Ships:** 324 triremes, 9 pentecontors

LOSSES

Men: unknown **Ships:** unknown	**Men:** unknown **Ships:** c.100 triremes sunk or captured

The Persian Emperor Xerxes invaded Greece in 480 with a massive army accompanied by an impressive fleet. While the Spartans confronted the Persian army at Thermopylae, a Greek fleet of 271 triremes, about half of them Athenian, was sent to Artemisium at the northern end of the island of Euboea. The fleet was commanded by a Spartan, Eurybiades, with Themistocles, the mastermind of Athenian naval expansion, as his second-in-command.

Sailing down the Greek coast the Persian fleet suffered heavily in a violent storm that, according to Herodotus, cost them 400 ships. But the force that reached the harbor of Aphetae, on the mainland north of Artemisium, in mid-August still far outnumbered the Greeks. Sensing the possibility of a crushing victory, the Persian commander Achaemenes sent 200 of his ships down the east coast of Euboea, hoping to sail around the south of the island and cut off the Greek fleet's line of withdrawal.

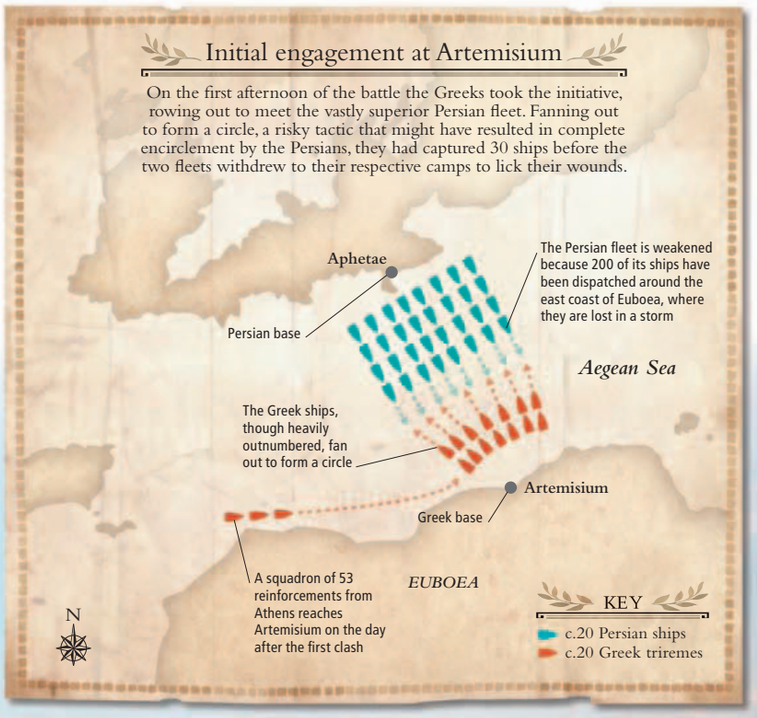
The fighting at Artesium began with a late afternoon sortie by the Greeks, apparently designed to test their enemy's mettle. The Greeks had by far the better of the resulting skirmish. With skilful rowing they rammed and captured 30 ships before nightfall.

The following day was a fortunate one for the Greeks. Another sudden storm wrecked the fleet of 200 Persian ships traveling along the exposed east coast of Euboea. Meanwhile, the Greek fleet was reinforced by the arrival of 53 more Athenian triremes. The Persians decided to seek a conclusive combat.

The next morning their fleet closed in on Artemisium in a sickle formation designed to block any escape from the bay. The Greeks rowed out vigorously, hoping to smash a way through the Persian line, but, by the time the fleets broke off combat, almost a third of their triremes had been sunk or captured.

Although the Persians had also suffered heavily, the news of the Persian victory on land at Thermopylae persuaded the Greek commanders to withdraw. They pulled back to the island of Salamis, where the decisive battle of the war would be fought.

> "THE BODIES OF THE SLAIN AND BROKEN PIECES OF THE DAMAGED SHIPS DRIFTED IN THE DIRECTION OF APHETAE, AND FLOATED ABOUT THE PROWS OF THE VESSELS THERE, DISTURBING THE ACTION OF THE OARS."
>
> **HERODOTUS**, DESCRIBING THE AFTERMATH OF THE FIRST CLASH OFF ARTEMISIUM



Sea around the island of Euboea
The Persian and Greek fleets clashed in the narrow straits that divide the Greek mainland from Euboea. The battle of Artemisium was fought at the northern end where the straits open out into the Aegean Sea.